



Rock steady: Pragganandhaa was the epitome of consistency. He defeated the two Chinese World Champions, Ding Liren (in pic) and Ju Wenjun, drew against the rest, and marginally raised his rating by four points. FRANS PEETERS

they make their Candidates debut in April.

In the Challengers section, Mendonca punched way above his weight to emerge champion. Seeded seventh in the field of 14, the youngster started with an expected victory over lowest-ranked Dutch Eline Roebers before drawing with lower-rated French Marc'Andria Maurizzi and Belgian Daniel Dardha. This slow start was followed by two losses in the space of three rounds that included a victory against D. Harika.

With three points from six rounds, Mendonca was far from his winning form. But what followed was a dramatic transformation.

He won the next three rounds, drew with top-seeded American Hans Moke Neimeann, and finished the home run with another hat-trick of victories, ending with the conquest of Divya Deshmukh.

Starting the event with a rating of 2608, Mendonca performed at 2742 to gain a whopping 23 rating points. Creditably, out of the eight victories, four came against higher-rated rivals.

Mendonca's title win came following a late twist to the tale.

Maurizzi remained a long-time leader and, with two rounds to go, enjoyed a one-point lead over Mendonca.

In the penultimate round, Dardha defeated Maurizzi, and Mendonca beat the UAE's Salem Saleh to catch up. In the final round, the experienced Dutch Erwin L'ami held Maurizzi, while Mendonca capitalised on a blunder from Divya to win and claim qualification to the 2025 Masters section.

Harika and Divya, rated among the last four players, managed to play marginally above their ratings.

Seeded 11th, Harika finished ninth after scoring two victories over lower-rated players, losing four and drawing the rest to add five rating points. Divya, seeded 13th, won three, lost seven, and drew three to gain four rating points.

Overall, the Indians had a good outing, with all six on view performing above their ratings.



RESULTS

Final standing (after 13 rounds):

Masters: 1-4. Wei Yi (Chn, 8.5), D. Gukesh (8.5), Anish Giri (8.5), Nodirbek Abdusattorov (Uzb, 8.5), 5-7. Alireza Firouzja (Fra, 7.5), Vidit Gujrathi (7.5), R. Pragganandhaa (7.5), 8. Ian Nepomniachtchi (FIDE, 6.5), 9. Ding Liren (Chn, 6), 10-13. Ju Wenjun (Chn, 4.5), Alexander Donchenko (Ger, 4.5), Jorden van Foreest (Ned, 4.5), 14. Max Warmerdam (Ned, 4).

Challengers:

1. Leon Mendonca (9.5 points), 2-3. Daniel Dardha (Bel, 9), Marc Andria Maurizzi (Fra, 9), 4-5. Erwin L'Ami (Ned, 8.5), Anton Korobov (Ukr, 8.5), 6. Saleh Salem (UAE, 7.5), 7-8. Hans Moke Niemann (USA, 7), Jaime Santos Latasa (Esp, 7), 9-10. Liam Vrolijk (Ned, 5.5), D. Harika (5.5), 11. Mustafa Yilmaz (Tur, 5), 12. Divya Deshmukh (4.5), 13. Stefan Beukema (Bel, 2.5), 14. Eline Roebers (Ned, 2).